

Cross-repo label taxonomy v1; readiness dimension unlocks agent assignment

vade-coo

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MEMO 2026-04-22-09 — Cross-repo label taxonomy v1; readiness dimension unlocks agent assignment

Issued: 2026-04-22 14:00 UTC **Author:** COO (via Claude Code local macOS session, batch-run) **Status:** active **Supersedes:** none. Formalizes and extends the informal label conventions that grew organically since MEMO 2026-04-11-20 made GitHub Issues + Projects authoritative. The retired `coo/project_tracker.md` flat-file (archived) is unaffected.

Context. Five `vade-app` repos have been accumulating labels ad hoc since bootstrap closed. `vade-coo-memory` grew `track:*`, `phase:*`, `proj:*`, `docs-only`, `needs:bdf1-approval`, `emancipatory`, `external-code`. `vade-core` grew `area:*` + `canvas`, `feat`, `milestone-1`, `epic:ipad-live`, `Discussion-update`, `C00 essay`. `vade-runtime` had only `area:deploy`, `area:mcp`. `vade-governance` had zero custom labels. `vade-agent-logs` had one: `Strategy`. No shared scheme; no way to filter the org project board for issues an agent could pick up versus issues that need human design or research first. Ven's instruction this session: standardize, and design an automation-amenable scheme that distinguishes ready-to-implement from requires-research.

Decision. Adopt the label taxonomy documented in `coo/label_taxonomy.md` (v1). Summary of the contract:

1. **Five dimensions**, prefix-namespaced for regex-based automation:

- `type:*` — bug / feat / chore / docs / refactor / test / research / epic (exactly one).
- `area:*` — where in the system (one or two; per-repo vocabulary, universal prefix).
- `readiness:*` — ready / needs-design / needs-research / needs-breakdown (exactly one; this is the headline dimension Ven asked for).
- `prio:*` — P0 / P1 / P2 / P3 (zero or one).
- `needs:*` / `blocked:*` / semantic flags (`emancipatory`, `external-code`) — additive qualifiers.

2. **Readiness drives agent routing.** `readiness:ready` marks issues a coding agent can start today; `readiness:needs-research` routes to a research agent; `readiness:needs-design` and `readiness:needs-breakdown` stay with humans until decomposed. This is the primary new filter for the VADE project board. The pattern matches what GitHub's own Copilot coding agent documentation calls out — agents transition issues through label states (`ready-for-dev` → `needs-testing` → `needs-review`); we adopt the “ready” half of that pattern now and leave the transition-labels unbuilt until a second agent exists to hand off to.

3. **Additive, not destructive.** No existing labels are deleted. Superseded labels (`track:*`, `canvas`, `feat`, `milestone-1`, `docs-only`, `phase:3-pilot`, `Strategy`, `epic:ipad-live`, `C00 essay`, `Discussion-update`) get “(deprecated: use X)” on their description and stay in place to avoid breaking history and closed-issue references. The migration is forward-only: new issues follow the scheme; existing issues are re-classified opportunistically as they’re touched, not via a mass-relabel sweep.
4. **Per-repo `area:*` drift is allowed; cross-repo `type/readiness/prio/needs/blocked` are invariants.** The prefixes are load-bearing for automation; value lists under `area:*` can grow per repo without coordination. Adding a new *prefix* (sixth dimension) is memo-worthy.
5. **Project board fields unchanged.** `State` (planned/active/blocked/done/parked) and `Owner` (Ven/COO/both) from the MEMO –11-20 board setup remain authoritative for lifecycle stage and driver — orthogonal to the label scheme. Labels describe the work; project fields describe where it sits in the pipeline.

Applied this session.

- `coo/label_taxonomy.md` written (canonical reference).
- All five repos updated additively: `type:*`, `readiness:*`, `prio:*` labels created everywhere; deprecated labels re-described; repo-specific `area:*` seeds added where missing.
- 23 open issues across the five repos classified. Issues with no clear readiness classification left without the label (implicit “untriaged”).
- Four orphan open issues (`vade-coo-memory` #22, #23; `vade-core` #54, #57) added to the VADE project with `State:planned` and `Owner` set to the best available signal.
- `vade-core` #5 (Epic: iPad-live) children converted from label-only linkage (`epic:ipad-live`) into official GitHub sub-issues, parallel to the maintenance pattern established for `vade-coo-memory` #20 last session.

What this enables. A future agent-assignment workflow can be written as a thin wrapper over the GitHub Issues API: filter by `readiness:ready`, read `type: + area:`, pick an agent profile from a lookup table, check `needs:bdf1-approval` as a gate, honour `blocked:*` as a hard stop. The router doesn’t exist yet; the inputs do.

What this does NOT change. Memo case-law protocol, `State/Owner` project fields, the sub-issue linkage pattern from last session’s #20 maintenance, the GitHub Issues + Projects authoritative-tracker rule from MEMO –11-20. The taxonomy sits below those in the stack — it describes issue content, not lifecycle.

Retirement condition. This memo retires when (a) the taxonomy is revised to v2 via a successor memo (new prefix, materially different semantics, or new dimension), or (b) a native GitHub feature subsumes the need for prefix-namespaced labels (e.g., typed custom issue fields at the repo level propagating to the org project board without manual label work). Until then, `coo/label_taxonomy.md` v1 is the canonical reference and this memo is the adoption record.